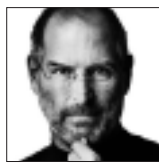


Steve Jobs gets raise

Steve Jobs, Guinness World Record holder for lowest paid CEO, drawing \$1 a year, will finally get a raise from Apple's Compensation Committee in accordance with the 10-K annual report for its fiscal year 2007.



Touch Cruise to sport 3G, GPS

HTC's new smartphone, the Touch Cruise, sports TouchFlo technology, which helps menu navigation by finger swipes. It is expected to compete with the iPhone on grounds of 3G for high-speed Internet access.



newsbytes

Whatever Happened To...

The Segway

We wonder if you recollect Ginger... the Ginger scooter, a.k.a. Segway the Human Transporter, unveiled in December 2001. It looked like a pogo stick on wheels. It was invented by Dean Kamen, who was probably bothered by skyrocketing oil prices and pollution issues. The Segway, a self-balancing scooter, was available for \$4,500 (Rs 1.8 lakh) was over-hyped as a "revolutionary" invention.

It weighed about 40 kg and used 260-cell custom-designed NiMH packs that produced 72 volts, the highest power of any currently-available chemistry. Twelve high-power, high-voltage field-effect transistors helped the user balance on the basis of the electric field generated.

The speed was determined by how far the user could lean forward or backward. But the scooters kept throwing users backwards at its maximum speed of 20 Kmph, thanks to a software glitch.

The human transporter got banned on footpaths and roadways—in fact, any public place, in countries like the UK and Japan—on the grounds of transport regulations.

A blogger named Maddox has slashed the hell out of the Segway, calling it a piece of junk. Read the post at <http://tinyurl.com/dahxg>—and get ready for inflammatory language. You know how bloggers are. So when will the Segway kindly step out?

LICENSING ISSUES

Google Locking Horns With Sun?

Google's heavily-anticipated mobile project was (finally) recently announced after bloggers, the developer community, and the phone industry players speculated to their wits' end about it. A new operating system for mobile phones called Android OS has been announced. To support the development of Android, 33 phone industry giants formed the Open Handset Alliance (OHA). Members include big names like Qualcomm, T-Mobile, Motorola, and HTC.

Android is Linux-based, and lives under the modified open source Apache license. Google wrote its own virtual machine for Android, named Dalvik. The developer community says Dalvik does have its technical merits and demerits, but they believe Google's didn't sufficiently emphasise the development of an entirely new platform. Google also released Android SDKs under a contest, offering \$10 million as rewards for cool apps from third-party developers.

But this has invited a reaction from Sun: it's about Sun's JME (Java Micro Edition). Apache Labs Developer and board member, Stefano Mazzochi, believes, "Google most likely built Dalvik as a way to get

around licensing issues with Sun that would have come with using JME."

A phone maker who wants to incorporate JME as the middleware platform on its handsets needs a license from Sun. However, any phone maker can make free use of JME freely under the open-



source

license if they share the applications they develop with the rest of the community. With Android, phone makers can make merry; licensing woes with Java might end if Android becomes mainstream.

The major concern is porting of applications on Android. Rich Green, executive vice president of software at Sun, shared a statement on this: "We're reaching out to Google and are anticipating they will be reaching out to us to ensure the software and APIs will be compatible so deployment on a wide variety of platforms will be possible. Sun wants to work with Google to prevent creating a

fractured mobile development environment."

Microsoft CEO Steve Ballmer was harshly critical of Android, calling it nothing more than a press release: "Well of course their efforts are just some words on paper right now, it's hard to do a very clear comparison (with Windows Mobile)." Symbian OS CEO Nigel Clifford has commented, "There's 10, 15, 20, maybe 25 different Linux platforms out there. It sometimes appears that Linux is fragmenting faster than it unifies."

The future of Android is dependent upon overcoming the technical demerits, enabling easy application porting, and eventually, making phone makers happy by easing licensing issues.

A NAME TO A FACE

Tag-You're It!

With thousands of photos being taken and stored, tagging photos—which is very good for retrieval—becomes a mammoth task. After taking multiple shots of the same person, it's hard to tag them all. What if your camera could recognise faces? FotoNation, a research and development company in the field of imaging and connectivity for the digital photography industry, recently announced a software that will make digital cameras

smarter, able to identify 25 to 30 people who are often photographed. The camera attaches tags as the picture is taken. This is a great leap for digital cameras—they can now recognise that there's a face in the frame and set focus, aperture and colour balance for a better picture. Also, face identification and tagging needs to happen before the next shot (usually within a second) and before the image is stored on the memory card, which again is a challenge.

FotoNation, which supplies face detection software to camera manufacturers, says the software can run on existing configurations, since it's trained to identify only a limited set of people. Panasonic, one of the camera manufacturers interested in auto-tagging, wants to go a step further—into the process called geotagging. This is used to look up photos the location of which you know, and check out the location of the



photos you have. Geotagging is a laborious manual task, which can be automated with GPS-based auto-tagging cameras.

With more efficient algorithms and increasing processing power, it probably won't be long before your camera starts to identify more than people—everyday objects, say? How about linking to a server, doing some matching, and tagging everything? But we can dream on...

DIY

Lock 'em Up

In the past, in countries like the US and the UK, cellular service providers decided upon network support for only specific cell phone models. But now even handset makers come out with customised phone models to work with different networks. Demand for such customised models rises outside the geographic confines of their release. A recent example is the iPhone. The world condemned Apple for customising it to only work with AT&T networks.

A few enthusiasts, however, found a loophole in the iPhone's SIM Lock and eventually hacked it to work over any network. Though providing support for such "unlocked" phones is a headache for service providers, they don't actively oppose unlocking. In certain countries, the handset makers themselves offer support for unlocking

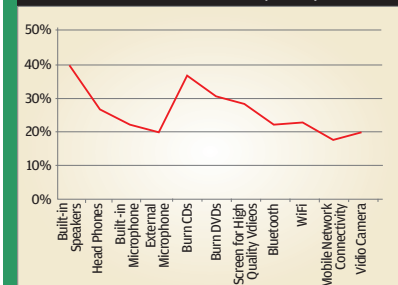
their customised phone models.

So we're wondering what it's all about: what's the point depriving customers of their dream phones? Is it a marketing strategy on the part of the handset makers? If so, why do they happily sacrifice their share of revenues to grey market merchants and exporters?

And then they get humiliated by college lads who hack their phones—

STAT ATTACK

Features in a PC that notebook buyers expect to use



Britons send more than 1 billion text messages weekly. The same number of messages was sent in all of 1999

With 6.7 million unique PS3 users in the Folding@home project, the network passed the one petaflop mark. The Guinness Book of Records recognised it as the most powerful distributed computing project

In a survey of both teens and adults in November, 43% of teens used IM for personal communication, 22% used it to ask people out and/or accept them, and another 13% to break up with someone

there are tutorials on the Internet, and local phone shops can help, too, to unlock phones to work with any network. And so it goes on, with the gadget freaks managing to purchase US-only and UK-only models from the grey market or wherever else—and using them. No-one seems to care.

CLEAN SCREEN

Oil-free, Dirt-resistant LCDs

A cleanliness drive comes to the mind of any laptop user when the hands are dirty. Commuters often find dirt, mud, and oil stains on their notebooks. Having lunch and dinner and coffee and beverages while working on the notebook can lead to damage at worst, but very often, stains.

Now, you can damage your notebook screen if you use certain generic

chemicals to clean it. To make the cleaning process easy and make the screen more dirt-resistant, LG Philips has announced a new "dirt-resistant" LCD panel for notebooks.

LG Philips says they'll employ a new coating at one go, which reduces glare and resists dirt at the same time. The new coating will even facilitate ink stain removal! Compare this to what it's like now: a special coating is used on LCD screens to reduce glare, but this one leads dirt and oil to easily stay on it. Applying a second coating for dirt resistance would be a time-consuming and expensive process.

Ahn Byung-chul, who leads development of advanced technology at LG Philips, has stated, "Our new panel employs a principle similar to that used on non-stick frying pans. Dirt and oil can easily be wiped away." The new dirt-resistant panel technology will be implemented first on 15.4-inch laptop screens made by LG Philips, which will go to production in the first half of 2008.